

1.5 Concluding Remarks

For a country like India, where on the one hand many are turning to PCs for the first time, and on the other hand many programmers are raking in a lot of foreign exchange, the decision to go either way can be difficult. Since most programmers are working on proprietary software, the decision to go with OSS will impact their long-term prospects. Delaying the acceptance of OSS by continuing to rely on proprietary software, pirated or otherwise, will negatively impact our ability to remain independent of the whims of a vendor.

Comparable OSS programs

Application Area	Propreitary	OS
Office Applications	MS Office	Openoffice.org
Graphics Editing	Adobe Photoshop	The GIMP
Desktop Publishing	Adobe Pagemaker	Scribus
SVG Editor	Corel Draw	Inkscape
Media Players	Windows Media Player, Winamp, Power DVD	Media Player Classic, VLC Media Player
Video Editors, Encoders	WinAvi, Imtoo	VirtualDub, Mediacoder

The OSS movement views software as a mundane item like a car: in real life, users can freely share information about the car, its engine specs, etc. In much the same vein, the role of the software is relegated as an accessory a to the hardware. Users pay for the hardware and get the required software for free. Any additional tweaking or troubleshooting should be carried out by the user, or by an expert who is paid by the user.